India–China rivalry in the Indian Ocean Region

Both China and India are stepping up their naval power and capacities. A number of factors drive India's naval ambition: India's wish to improve its ability to provide humanitarian assistance and disaster relief (HADR), its constabulary role and patrolling duties related to the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), its need to protect sea lanes of communications, and its desire to secure its national interests.[86] National interests are increasingly understood in light of China's increasing ambitions in the Indian Ocean Region.[87] Indian Navy Chief Admiral Sunil Lanba recently stated that India is challenged by China's presence in the northern Indian Ocean Region and that New Delhi is closely monitoring the deployment of Chinese ships and submarines.[88]

India's naval rise has been gradual. During the 1960s, Prime Minister Indira Gandhi requested that major powers withdraw from the Indian Ocean out of concern for the potential of great power rivalry in an area of vital importance to India; this request suited India's self-perception as a non-aligned state at the time. During India's economic reorientation of the 1990s, however, the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) government took steps to increase engagement with the Indian Ocean Region and its littoral states. When Modi came to power as Prime Minister in 2014, he further prioritised the region and scaled up engagement. During a 2015 visit to the Seychelles and Mauritius, Modi announced a fivefold framework for India's policy towards the Indian Ocean Region: maintaining security, deepening security co-operation with littoral states, strengthening multilateral maritime security co-operation, furthering sustainable economic development, and co-operating with major powers.[89]